

Q What problems or conditions could my newborn encounter?

When you consider the myriad cell divisions and biological processes that are involved in making a baby, it is little wonder that sometimes things go wrong and babies are born with conditions that need treatment in their first months of life, or that require ongoing care. The earlier a problem is identified, the sooner treatment or attention can be given, and often this lessens any long-term repercussions for your baby.

Respiratory Distress Syndrome (RDS)

» What is this?

In order to inflate properly, a newborn baby's lungs need sufficient amounts of surfactant—a fluid that keeps the lungs inflated and prevents the air sacs within them from collapsing when your baby starts to breathe on her own at birth. The air sacs begin to produce surfactant at around 27 weeks of pregnancy. Babies born before 31 weeks don't have sufficient surfactant to enable the lungs to take in air properly, which leads to RDS. Your baby will show signs of breathing difficulties at birth, which will vary in severity depending upon how prematurely she was born, and symptoms worsen in the following days if left untreated. Some babies will need to go on to a ventilator immediately to begin breathing, while others may show signs of rasping or grunting as they try to fill their lungs.

» What can be done?

If there's time, you may be given steroids as soon as you go into premature labor to speed up the development of your baby's lungs. Once your baby is born, she may need to go into an incubator, where she can be given surfactant through a tube that goes into her mouth and directly into her tiny lungs. When she is stable, she will be put on a ventilator, which mechanically fills her lungs with air, breathing for her; or a continuous positive airways pressure machine, which allows her to breathe on her own, but prevents her lungs from collapsing between breaths.

» What does this mean for my baby?

The potential effects of RDS depend upon your baby's gestational age at birth. With quick treatment, and gentle but steady progress, your baby is likely to make a full recovery. Some babies will need help with breathing for just a few days, but if your baby was very premature, she may need assistance for weeks; sometimes it can take many months for a premature baby's lungs to work properly. Many very premature babies have RDS that develops into chronic lung disease.

Congenital infections

Viral or bacterial infections present at birth are called congenital infections, passed to the baby from the mother via the placenta in pregnancy, or during birth. The table here shows some common infections. Others include toxoplasmosis, hepatitis, HIV, and CMV.

INFECTION	WHAT IS IT?	WHAT CAN BE DONE?
Group B streptococcus (GBS infection)	A baby may contract group B streptococcus infection during birth from a mother carrying the bacteria. The baby develops blood poisoning, which can cause serious complications. Premature infants are at greater risk.	Fast treatment with antibiotics leads to no long-term effects. If the mother is a known carrier, the baby will receive antibiotics as soon as she is born to prevent the spread of infection. When the infection isn't known about, the baby may have signs such as unresponsiveness, breathing difficulties, convulsions, poor temperature control, and pale skin.
Herpes	The herpes simplex virus comes in two forms—HSV1, which causes cold sores; and HSV2, which causes genital herpes. HSV2 is most common in newborns, who catch the virus during birth. It is a potentially serious infection that can cause severe conditions, or even neonatal death.	If you know or suspect you have genital herpes, your doctor may advise a cesarean section to prevent the spread of the virus to your baby. If not, and your baby contracts the infection, she may have no symptoms at first, and may go on to be perfectly healthy. If the virus activates, babies may be unresponsive, have difficulty feeding, and have a fever. Your baby will need intravenous antiviral medication for up to three weeks to control the infection.
Rubella	Also known as German measles, this is a viral infection that can cause serious complications for premature infants (see p.139). Congenital rubella occurs when the baby contracts the virus in the uterus in the first trimester. It can cause developmental problems, which can affect the heart, and the nervous and musculoskeletal systems.	There is no way to treat the rubella infection itself, so treatment involves minimizing its effects. Some babies will be able to have heart surgery to correct defects. Sadly, any damage to brain tissues is permanent.